

The Dance School Awards: Industry Award - Dance Teacher of the Year:

Dance Teacher of the Year Application / Nomination Questions.

Please find below 5 questions which we will need you to answer to proceed with your nomination.

Judges will consider:

- Quality and clarity of teaching practice
- Ability to motivate, inspire, and support students
- Awareness of different learning needs and pathways
- Commitment to student wellbeing and safe practice
- Evidence of professional integrity and reliability
- Ongoing professional development
- Positive impact within their school or community
- Commitment to inclusive and respectful teaching practice that supports a diverse range of students
- A clear case for why this teacher stands out this year

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Joy in Motion

1. What makes you an exceptional teacher? *

I believe exceptional teaching is about far more than delivering choreography – it is about helping people discover confidence, connection and joy through movement.

As a qualified secondary school teacher with a Master's degree in Dance Movement Psychotherapy, I bring together educational expertise, creativity and a deep understanding of how movement can positively impact both physical and emotional wellbeing. I understand that every individual learns differently, so I carefully adapt my teaching to suit a wide range of abilities, learning styles and confidence levels, ensuring everyone feels supported whilst still being challenged to grow.

What truly sets me apart is the environment I create. My classes are inclusive, welcoming and completely free from judgement. Many adults arrive believing they "can't dance", that they're too old to start or lacking the confidence to join in. Seeing those same people perform with pride, laugh without inhibition and leave feeling stronger than when they arrived is the greatest reward.

I combine high expectations with genuine warmth and encouragement. My students know they will be challenged, but they also know they will always be supported. My aim is not simply to teach dance; it is to help people discover what they are capable of.

2. How do you support and inspire your students? *

Creating a safe, supportive and encouraging environment is at the heart of everything I do.

I celebrate every achievement, whether that's mastering a difficult routine, attending class for the very first time or simply finding the confidence to dance without worrying what others think. I remind my students that progress looks different for everyone and that joy is just as important as technique.

Joy in Motion has become much more than a dance class. It has grown into a community where people encourage one another, celebrate each other's successes and build genuine friendships. Watching participants support each other both inside and outside the studio is something I am incredibly proud of. I also believe that leading by example inspires others. Building my own business has taken resilience, courage and determination, and I hope that by pursuing my own dreams I encourage others to believe they can pursue theirs too.

The greatest compliment I receive is when students tell me my class is the highlight of their week, that they feel happier because of it or that they have rediscovered a part of themselves they thought they had lost.

3. How do you continue to develop professionally? *

I am passionate about continuous professional development because I believe great teachers never stop learning.

Alongside my teaching qualification and Master's degree, I regularly reflect on my practice, seek participant feedback and adapt my sessions to ensure they remain engaging, inclusive and effective.

I take my responsibility as a teacher seriously and regularly update my safeguarding and first aid training so I can provide a safe environment where every participant feels cared for and supported.

Over the past year I have continued to develop both as an educator and as a business owner by expanding Joy in Motion into new venues, creating new class opportunities, developing movement for wellbeing sessions, delivering wedding choreography and offering fun, confidence-building hen party dance experiences. Every new experience strengthens my teaching and allows me to reach different communities through dance.

I believe learning is lifelong, and I continually invest in developing my skills so I can offer the very best experience to everyone who joins my classes.

4. What impact have you had in the last year? *

The last year has been transformational.

I have grown Joy in Motion from a vision into a thriving dance community, expanding into new venues and creating more opportunities for adults to experience the joy of musical theatre dance in a welcoming and inclusive environment.

Alongside my three weekly classes, I have delivered movement for wellbeing sessions, choreographed memorable first dances for wedding couples and provided energetic hen party dance experiences. These sessions have enabled me to introduce dance to people who may never have considered themselves dancers, creating unforgettable memories while building confidence and bringing people together through movement.

The impact I am most proud of is the transformation I see in my students. I have watched people overcome anxiety, gain confidence, improve their wellbeing, perform in front of others for the first time and develop lasting friendships. Many students tell me they feel happier, healthier and more confident because of Joy in Motion.

For me, success isn't measured solely by numbers—it's measured by the positive difference I make to people's lives.

5. Why should you be recognised now? *

I believe now is the right time because Joy in Motion has grown into something that is changing lives through dance.

Over the past year I have shown determination, resilience and creativity in building an inclusive dance community that welcomes adults of all ages, abilities and backgrounds. I have expanded my work beyond weekly classes to include wellbeing programmes, wedding choreography and hen party experiences, making dance accessible to an even wider audience.

Everything I do is rooted in the belief that dance should be for everyone. Whether someone joins me to improve their wellbeing, celebrate a special occasion, learn a first dance or simply try something new, my goal is always the same: to help them leave feeling more confident, more connected and full of joy.

Receiving this award would not only recognise my work as a teacher but also celebrate the incredible achievements of my students, whose courage to step through the studio door and embrace something new inspires me every single week.

I am immensely proud of what I have built, and even prouder of the community that continues to grow around Joy in Motion. If my teaching has helped people discover confidence, friendship and happiness through dance, then I believe I have made a meaningful and lasting contribution to the lives of those I teach.

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